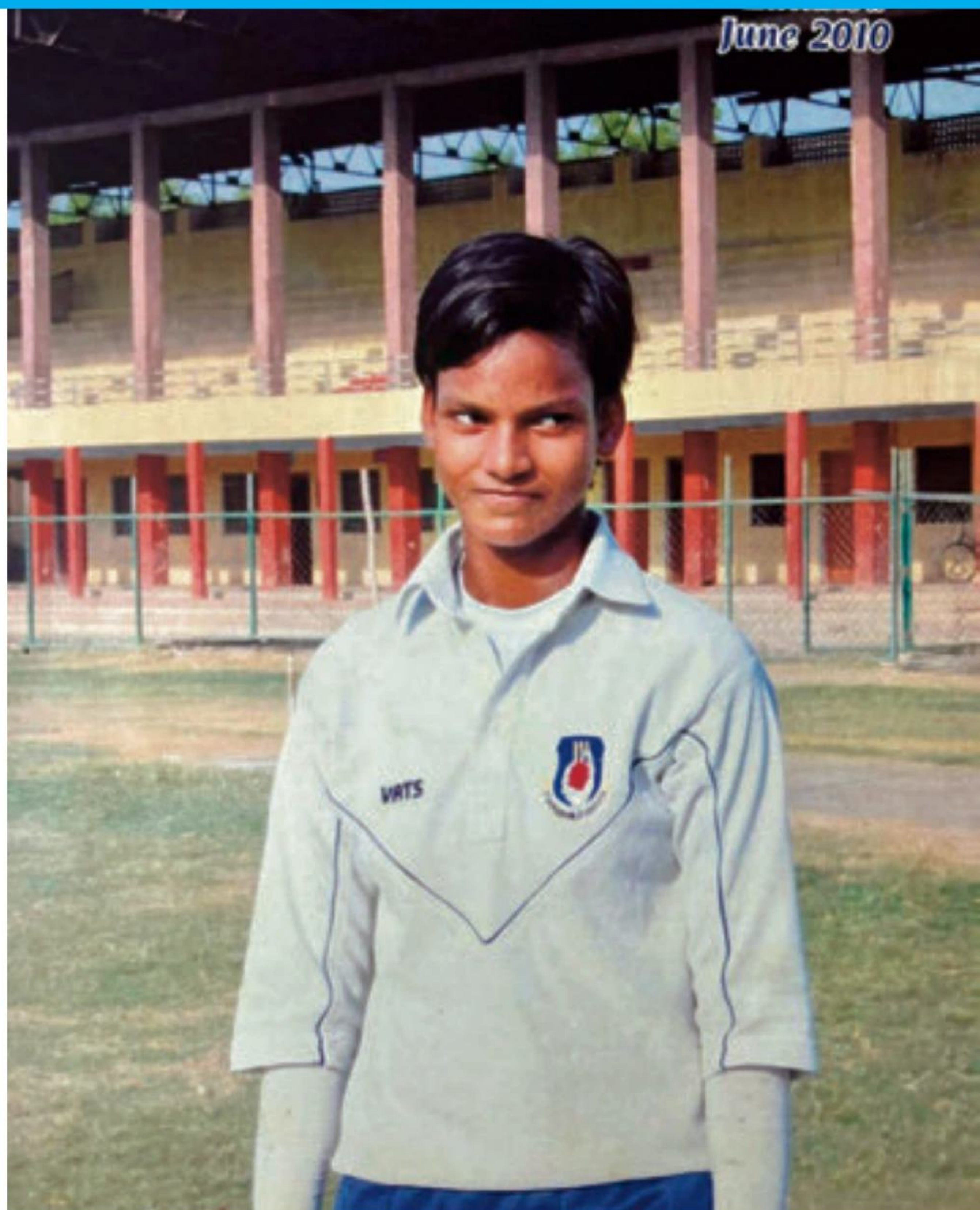




Guiding bond: From a girl holding a bat in Agra, learning to believe in what might be, to the easy laughter she now shares with Rita (facing page), the mentor who became family, these moments trace the making of Deepti Sharma.

Pics: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

but it's come the hard way. In 2018, during a series against England, Deepti's brother Sumit called me in the middle of a workday at All India Radio, saying he was worried about how Deepti would fare. I reached out, and she called me to discuss her grievances, including some issues she was having with a certain shot. That eventually ended with her crying. We spoke for a long time about how that was not going to help. Shots were analysed, variations discussed, and Deepti went and won Player of the Match in the next match, the third ODI in Nagpur," Rita says.

Rita remembers that year and how its experiences created confusion for Deepti. She insisted on moving to Bengal in the domestic circuit to work alongside Jhulan. UPCA, with the help of veteran administrator Rajiv Shukla, finally

brought her back in 2022.

The 2017 World Cup marked a shift in how the world viewed Deepti. Alongside Smriti Mandhana and Harmanpreet Kaur, the all-rounder became a sought-after name in the franchise circuit, heading first to the now-defunct Kia Super League before finding takers in the Women's Big Bash League and The Hundred. From 2023, she also had access to high-quality T20 cricket at home with the Women's Premier League.

An accumulator as a batter until then, these franchise stints forced Deepti to unlock pace and intent in a game increasingly favouring the fast and the brave. Winning the Most Valuable Player Award in the 2024 edition of the WPL underlined her evolution, a season in which she scored 295 runs at an average of 98.33, striking at 136.57.

The sweep shot is Deepti's go-to



*** Deepti Sharma** is the first player with a fifty and a five-for in a women's World Cup match.

*** Her 22 wickets** are the joint second-highest in a Women's World Cup.

*** Deepti is also the first player** to do the double of 200-plus runs and 20-plus wickets in a World Cup, having scored 215 runs, including three fifties, and taken two four-plus wicket hauls.